

Always-On Personal Agents as Competing Operating Primitives: A Comparative Study of OpenAI Dots and Grok Bot

Technical briefing compiled from vendor documentation and contemporaneous reporting
Working paper / not peer reviewed

September 29, 2026

Abstract

Persistent agents with dedicated cloud computers became a product category in August–September 2026. This working paper compares two instantiations of that category on the day OpenAI shipped Dots at DevDay 2026: OpenAI Dots, a single named chief-of-staff embedded in ChatGPT and powered by GPT-6 Astra; and Grok Bot (SpaceXAI / xAI, distributed through Cursor), a roster of named teammates that share one user-scoped cloud computer. We argue that the products implement the same primitive—an always-on agent, a durable machine, a connector graph, and an approval gate—but disagree on the unit of work. Dots attaches a virtual machine to an agent and postpones multi-agent coordination. Grok Bot attaches a virtual machine to a user and already routes work across named roles, including Team Bots launched on 28 September 2026. The paper tabulates architecture, memory, channels, pricing, safety controls, and recommended operating conditions, and proposes a fourteen-day bake-off protocol. It is a research snapshot, not a benchmark and not an endorsement.

Keywords: persistent agents, cloud computers, ChatGPT Dots, Grok Bot, multi-agent systems, approval gates, Team Bots, specialist Dots

1 Introduction

By late September 2026 the industry had converged on a form factor that is no longer a chatbot. Meta Muse (8 September), Instinct, OpenClaw, Poke, Gemini Spark and related systems all give a model a durable workspace and permission to continue after the session ends. Two products now sit at the center of the work-agent debate.

OpenAI Dots launched on 29 September 2026 inside ChatGPT [1, 2, 4, 3]. Grok Bot launched in early beta on 11 August 2026, widened to paid Cursor and SuperGrok plans on 26 August, and added Team Bots on 28 September [8, 9, 11, 12, 13].

The public copy is almost interchangeable: always-on, own computer, works while the laptop is closed, asks before irreversible acts. The implementations are not interchangeable. This paper treats them as competing operating primitives rather than as feature checklists. Figure 1 states the shared stack; Figure 2 places both products on the 2026 calendar.



shared primitive $P = (M, V, C, G)$; products differ on how V is bound and how many agents share C, G .

Figure 1: The shared always-on primitive. Both Dots and Grok Bot instantiate a model M , a durable machine V , a tool graph C , and a gate G . Marketing copy collapses these four boxes into “always-on agent.”

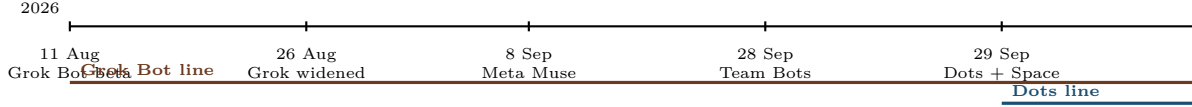


Figure 2: Product timeline, August–September 2026. Grok Bot had six weeks of paid production and a team-agent launch the day before Dots. Dots arrives with Space and a specialist-Dot preview, not a roster.

2 Method and scope

Sources are limited to vendor documentation, Help Center and Learn pages, launch posts, and same-day third-party reporting [14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24]. No head-to-head task suite exists for Dots on launch day. Claims marked as vision—“teams of Dots,” SMS waitlists, Agent 365 pilots—are labelled as such. Prices and geo gates move; figures below are those published or consistently reported on 29 September 2026.

3 Product definitions

OpenAI Dots. An always-on agent that lives in the ChatGPT sidebar. Each Dot is powered by GPT-6 Astra, receives its own cloud computer and browser, and connects through ChatGPT’s plugin ecosystem (OpenAI cites more than 4,000 apps). Users reach a Dot in ChatGPT (web and desktop; mobile after desktop creation), Slack and Microsoft Teams; in-app voice exists; SMS / iMessage / RCS is waitlisted. Day-one cardinality is one primary Dot per eligible account. OpenAI “envision[s] teams of Dots working together” and is previewing specialist Dots with a distinct identity for organizations, including a path into Microsoft Agent 365 [1, 4, 3].

Grok Bot. A roster of persistent named teammates. Each account receives one persistent cloud computer—browser, filesystem, terminal—that all of that user’s Bots share [12]. Bots use connectors where they exist and computer-use where they do not. They keep role-specific memory, message one another, sit in group chats, learn workflows from a live demonstration (skill $\rightarrow$ routine), and wake on schedules or webhooks. Team Bots let a team share context, plugins, credentials and memories while keeping each person’s threads private [9]. Surfaces are a standalone desktop app (macOS, Windows, Linux) plus iOS and Android. Grok Bot is not a mode of Grok chat and not a mode of ChatGPT.

4 The architectural fork

This is the load-bearing difference.

Dots attaches a machine to an agent. Learn documentation states that the Dot lives in the cloud with its own computer and browser; the user may inspect the machine, take over mouse and

keyboard, then return control. Connecting a personal computer is a separate opt-in, one machine at a time, off by default. A login on the user’s laptop does not sign the Dot in. Cloud work continues with local devices off [6, 3]. If OpenAI later sells a second Dot, the natural reading of “own cloud computer” is a second isolated workspace.

Grok Bot attaches a machine to a user. Official FAQ language is unambiguous: every Bot on the account uses one persistent cloud computer; they share files, browser sessions and logins so handoffs work without repeating setup. Isolation is per user, not per Bot. Documentation warns operators not to treat separate Bots as a security boundary. Each Bot receives its own screen on the shared machine; one computer-use task per Bot screen at a time [12, 11].

The failure modes invert. If the constraint is “the research agent must never see the client CRM cookies,” a per-agent VM (Dots today, specialist Dots later) is the cleaner design. If the constraint is “the human must not be the router between Researcher, Writer and Sender,” Grok Bot already solves the coordination problem and Dots does not. Figure 3 draws the binding; Figure 4 draws the unit of work.

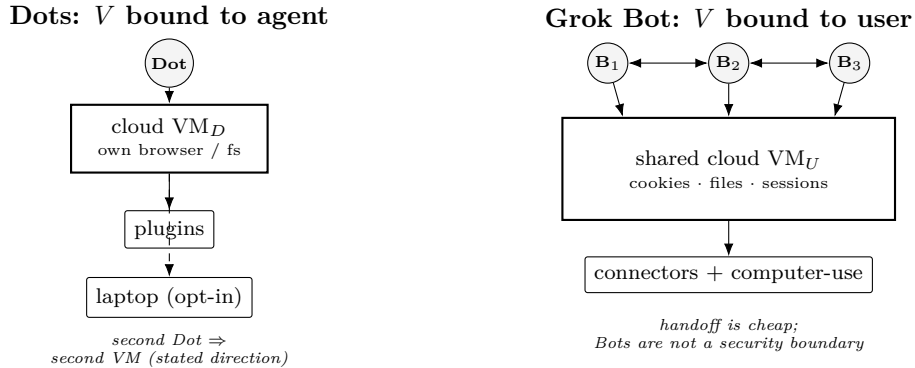


Figure 3: Where the virtual machine is attached. Left: Dots gives the named agent its own computer. Right: Grok Bot gives the account one computer and lets named Bots share sessions. The edge $B_i \leftrightarrow B_j$ is productized on Grok Bot (DM, group chat, ownership transfer) and only promised on Dots.



Figure 4: Unit of work. Dots optimizes the single long-running counterpart. Grok Bot optimizes a staffed channel. “Teams of Dots” would move the left diagram toward the right; it is not shipping on 29 September 2026.

5 Master comparison

Dimension	OpenAI Dots	Grok Bot
Vendor	OpenAI	SpaceXAI / xAI, shipped via Cursor
Public launch	29 Sep 2026 (DevDay)	11 Aug 2026; widened 26 Aug; Team Bots 28 Sep
Metaphor	One chief of staff in ChatGPT	A roster of named coworkers
Agents on day one	One primary Dot per person	Many named Bots per account
Multi-agent now	Vision only	DM, group chats, handoffs, parallel
Org / team agent	Specialist Dots preview; Agent 365 path	Team Bots generally available
Home surface	ChatGPT sidebar + Slack + Teams	Standalone Grok Bot app
Desktop	ChatGPT desktop (create here)	Native macOS, Windows, Linux
Mobile	After desktop create; no mobile-web create	iOS and Android companion
Model	GPT-6 Astra (fixed)	Grok 4.6 / 4.7 mix; no user picker
Cloud computer	One VM per Dot	One VM per user, shared by all Bots
Agent isolation	Stronger between agents	Weak between Bots; strong between users
Local computer	Optional, off by default, one machine	Optional; separate from the cloud VM
Integrations	4,000+ ChatGPT plugins	Connectors + computer-use + native X
Background mode	Proactive research, read-only on connected apps	Skills, routines, schedules, webhooks
Parallelism	Background agents under one Dot	Multiple Bots; one computer-use task per screen
Voice	In-app / phone-style call	In-app voice
Unique channel	ChatGPT's existing weekly-user surface	Native X search, timeline, mentions
Coding path	Delegates into Codex / ChatGPT Work	Sibling of Grok Build / Cursor; separate usage bucket
Collaboration canvas	ChatGPT Space	Group chats, shared VM files, Team Bots
Entry price (public)	Bundled in ChatGPT Pro / Business Premium	Cursor Pro \$20 or SuperGrok \$30
Chat metering	Dot conversation does not consume ChatGPT caps	Bot usage does not consume Grok-chat / editor quota
Heavy-work meter	Codex / Work tasks count as usual	Weekly Bot grant; optional on-demand
Self-host	None	None
Geo gate	Pro blocked in EEA, CH, UK at launch	No equivalent published consumer block
Maturity on this date	Hours old; early tester friction reported [15]	Six weeks in paid production plus internal case studies [10]

6 Memory and coordination

Dots keep a continuous personal context across ChatGPT, Slack and Teams. The Dot uses the active conversation, relevant ChatGPT memory, and its own saved notes. It can run several responsibilities in one thread, spawn background agents, create visible side threads, pause and wake itself, and trigger on a time or a supported event. Connecting Slack alone does not create a monitor; the job must be assigned. OpenAI states that it does not train directly on proactive research or the Dot's

notes to itself [5, 2].

Grok Bot splits memory by role. Each Bot has a job, a conversation and role context. Shared state lives on the computer and in group chats. Skills are saved methods. Routines bind a skill to a schedule, event or webhook. Demonstration learning—watch the user complete a path once—is a documented primitive that Dots has not shipped as a product feature. Team Bots add team-scoped context with per-user private threads [9, 11].

Memory layer	Dots	Grok Bot
Personal long-term	ChatGPT memory + Dot notes	Per-Bot role memory
Cross-channel	ChatGPT / Slack / Teams / voice	Same Bots on desktop and mobile
Cross-agent	Not shipped	Handoffs, DMs, group chats, shared VM
Team-shared expertise	Specialist Dots (preview)	Team Bots (28 Sep 2026)
Workflow capture	Custom Rules + assigned work	Skills + demonstration + routines
Triggers	Time or supported event; self-wake	Schedule, event, webhook

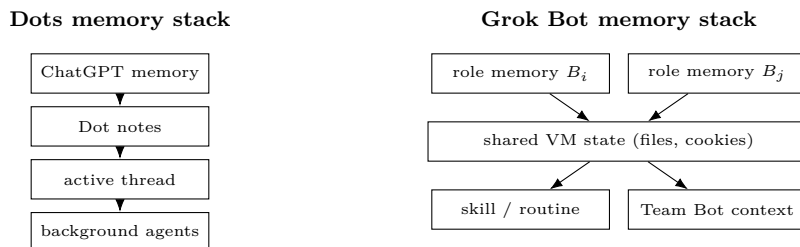


Figure 5: Memory topology. Dots stacks personal state under one agent. Grok Bot partitions role state and reunites it on the shared machine. Team Bot context is a fourth layer, orthogonal to per-user threads.

7 Distribution, workspace and coding

Dots wins distribution. It sits in ChatGPT next to New chat, inherits the plugin graph, and speaks Slack and Teams on day one. ChatGPT Space is the collaboration bet: a persistent page where humans, ChatGPT and a Dot share artifacts instead of trapping work in one private thread [20]. Coding is delegated. When a Dot starts Codex or ChatGPT Work tasks, those tasks hit the existing usage meters [1].

Grok Bot wins the dedicated workstation. The app is built around a roster, presence cues, artifacts and an Agent Computer panel. Coding lives next door in Cursor / Grok Build. Bot usage is documented as a separate weekly bucket from Grok chat and the Cursor editor [25]. Computer-use on sites with no MCP or API is more central to the Grok story than to Dots, which leads with the plugin graph and treats the browser as the Dot’s own machine. Figure 6 maps the surfaces.

8 Pricing and access

Neither product has a standalone SKU.

Dots is listed on OpenAI’s public ChatGPT pricing matrix under Pro and not under Plus, Free or Go [7]. Independent recaps place Pro in a \$100–\$200 family and Business Premium near

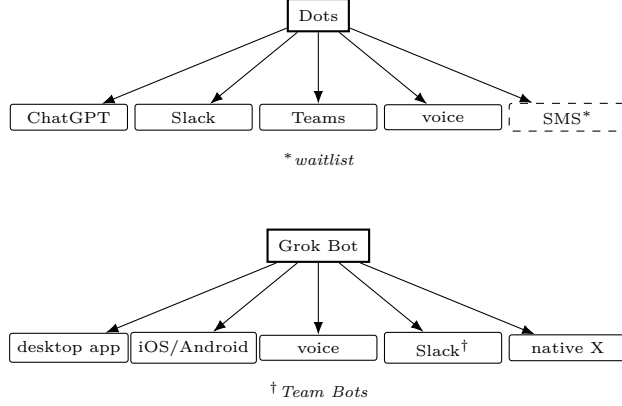


Figure 6: Channel surfaces. Dots borrows ChatGPT’s existing graph. Grok Bot is a standalone workstation with an X connector that Dots does not have.

\$125 per month; a \$500 tier was announced the same day [22, 16]. The first Dot is included. Conversations with the Dot do not count against ChatGPT message caps; Codex and Work tasks do. OpenAI extended deeper-work limits for the first month. Enterprise, Edu and Healthcare workspaces receive a beta that an administrator must enable. Pro users in the EEA, Switzerland and the United Kingdom are excluded at launch; Business Premium is described as wider [21, 3].

Grok Bot is included with paid Cursor plans from Cursor Pro at \$20 per month and with SuperGrok at \$30, plus higher individual and team seats up to Cursor Ultra (\$200) and SuperGrok Heavy (\$300) [25, 13]. Each plan carries a weekly Bot allowance that resets independently of Grok-chat and editor quotas. Extra usage can be billed on demand against a cap the operator sets. There is no published per-task count for the weekly grant.

9 Safety, approvals and privacy

Both vendors treat a cloud agent with app logins as a different risk class from a chatbot. Both use a two-layer pattern: user-authored policy for everyday autonomy, and a separate reviewer the agent cannot disable. Figure 7 is the common pipeline.

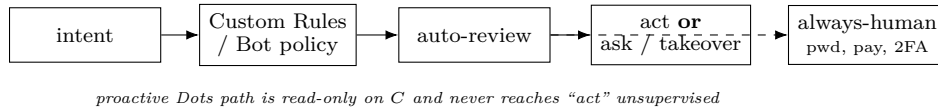


Figure 7: Approval pipeline shared by both products. Policy is user-authored. Auto-review is a second model the agent cannot turn off. A reserved class of actions never leaves the human. The dashed edge is the hard stop (passwords, payments, deletes).

Dots. Built-in rules decide whether to act or ask. Custom Rules allow four behaviors: take action without asking; take action if pre-approved in the prompt; ask first; hand off [3]. Dots may draft rules; they may not change them without the user. Auto-review is a separate checker for actions that affect accounts or share information—OpenAI’s example is a wrong email recipient. Password changes, permanent deletes and similar classes stay with the human. Proactive research is restricted to read-only on connected apps. Monitoring can pause or stop the Dot. A dedicated safety post shipped with the product [2]. Local computer access starts off.

Grok Bot. Passwords, passkeys, two-factor codes, CAPTCHAs, payments and identity checks are handed back via takeover on the Agent Computer. Auto Review can sit in front of outbound actions. Enterprise adds access, network and audit controls, SSO / SCIM, and on higher tiers customer-managed keys or a dedicated data plane. Privacy Mode and training opt-out are documented. The distinctive disclosure is the shared-computer warning [12].

Category risk. Meta Muse had already encountered an Amazon block and a reported address leak before Dots launched [23]. OpenAI had publicly discussed other agent-sandbox incidents in the preceding months. Neither product is safe in the sense of zero blast radius. Capability scales with the keys handed over.

Control	Dots	Grok Bot
User policy	Custom Rules (four behaviors)	Approvals + Bot-level instructions
Separate reviewer	Auto-review; Dot cannot disable it	Auto Review on sensitive outbound
Always-human actions	Passwords, permanent deletes, &c.	Passwords, 2FA, CAPTCHA, payments
Background constraint	Proactive layer is read-only	Routines can act; gated by review
Pause	Profile → Pause	Stop Bot / revoke computer / disable routine
Org identity	Specialist Dot identity + Agent 365	Team Bots + Enterprise IAM
Training on notes	Not directly on proactive research / self-notes	Training opt-out / Privacy Mode documented

10 Recommended operating conditions

Situation	Prefer	Reason
Already live in ChatGPT / Codex / Slack / Teams	Dots	No new app; inherited plugins and memory
Need three to six parallel roles tonight	Grok Bot	Roster, shared VM and group chats exist now
One-person company, \$20–30 budget	Grok Bot	Cursor Pro / SuperGrok door
Need Astra-class computer use on one long goal	Dots	Frontier model is the default
Team must share one agent’s expertise	Grok Team Bots now	Team Bots shipped; specialist Dots are pilots
Client-separated credentials	Dots, or two Grok accounts	Grok Bots on one login share cookies
Social listening on X	Grok Bot	Native X connector
EEA / UK consumer on Pro	Grok Bot, or wait	Dots Pro geo-blocked at launch
Audit, SSO, SCIM this quarter	Either Enterprise path	Both selling governance
Preference against new surfaces	Dots	Lives where the chat already is
Teach-by-doing once	Grok Bot	Demonstration → skill → routine is documented

11 What is not yet real

Launch-day copy should be read as intent, not inventory.

- Dots “teams” are a sentence in a blog post. A Researcher / Writer / Sender roster cannot be staffed inside ChatGPT today.
- Specialist Dots and Agent 365 are pilots and partnership language, not a self-serve toggle.
- SMS and iMessage for Dots remain a waitlist.
- Grok Bot weekly allowances are ranked (“below Pro+”) rather than published as task counts.
- No independent head-to-head task suite includes Dots on 29 September 2026.
- Early Dots builds, per contemporaneous testing, confused which computer, browser or thread owned the work [15].
- Model identity will drift. “Astra versus Grok 4.7” is a model comparison and will be stale within a month.

12 A fourteen-day bake-off protocol

Do not compare homepages. Give both agents the same three jobs and score the artifacts. Figure 8 is the protocol.

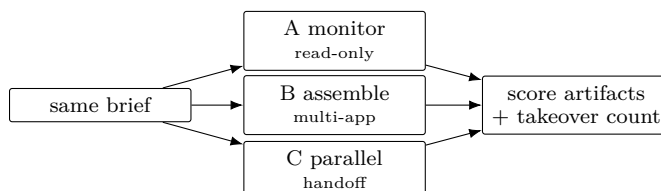


Figure 8: Fourteen-day bake-off. Week one is observation. Week two may add local-computer access if Job B requires it. The takeover count on the VM is the interface metric; homepage copy is not.

Job A — Monitor. “Watch this inbox or Slack channel for class X , draft a reply, do not send.” Score false positives, missed items, and whether the agent stayed read-only.

Job B — Multi-app assemble. “Pull last week’s notes from a connected document store, turn them into a one-pager, leave it for review.” Score completeness, invented sources, and how missing logins were requested.

Job C — Parallel roles. On Grok Bot, staff two Bots and force a handoff. On Dots, ask one Dot to run two workstreams and inspect Activity View. Score whether the human had to be the router.

Hold budget, secrets and production sends until week two. Revoke local-computer access unless Job B requires it. Count takeovers of the virtual machine. That count is the real interface.

13 Conclusion

The category is settled: a persistent agent, a cloud computer, a connector graph, an approval gate. The operating theory is not. OpenAI is betting that one Astra-class agent inside a surface with more than a billion weekly users is the correct default, with multi-agent structure arriving later as specialist Dots and Space. xAI is betting that work already has named owners, that those owners should share a machine, and that the product to ship first is the roster—even if the model is not the industry’s headline frontier system.

On 29 September 2026, Grok Bot is the more complete multi-agent operating system. Dots is the stronger single-agent, single-surface, single-model wager. Operators should choose the primitive that matches the failure mode they actually have, then run the bake-off in Section 10 before moving secrets onto either machine.

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